Production document

Cultural Guide and Glossary

How Khmer culture is researched, reviewed and represented: advisor process, topic briefings, the master glossary, the sensitive content register and the review log.

Status	Draft. Every entry is to be confirmed by the cultural advisor
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01 Purpose and Principles

This game asks players around the world to experience Khmer belief and history. That is a privilege and a responsibility. This document keeps the representation accurate, respectful and reviewed.

Principle	Meaning
Research before invention	Start from real practice and belief; invent only where the story needs it, and mark inventions clearly in the design documents.
Respectful horror	The fear comes from the spirits and the debt, never from mocking or desecrating real religion.
Living culture	These are beliefs and practices people hold today, not exotic decoration. Write as if Cambodian players are the first audience.
Cambodian voices decide	When the advisors say something is wrong or hurtful, it changes.
Fiction is labelled	The specific pact, the seals and the rules of the debt are fiction. The game's credits or opening note can say so.

02 Working with Advisors

Who	One or two Cambodian advisors with knowledge of village religious practice (for example a family elder, a monk or lay temple leader, a university scholar of Khmer studies or a cultural organisation). A native-speaking translator for Khmer text.
When	For every episode: (1) story outline, (2) greybox with script, (3) release candidate. Plus ad-hoc questions while writing.
What to send	The specific scenes, lines, images or items in question, the context, and a clear question. Avoid sending entire documents without guidance.
Recording	Every question and answer goes in the review log (section 7) with the date and the decision.
Respect their time	Pay an honorarium where possible; credit advisors by name (or anonymously, if preferred); share the finished episode with them first.

03 Topic Briefings

Each briefing summarises general understanding as a starting point for research. Nothing here is final until confirmed by an advisor.

Topic	General understanding	How the game uses it · to confirm
Neak Ta អ្នកតា	Guardian spirits tied to a place (a village, a field, a forest, water). Often represented by a stone, a statue or a small shrine. People make offerings and ask for protection; Neak Ta are respected and can punish disrespect.	A guardian enforcing a contract; a judge, not a demon. Confirm that a pact with a Neak Ta for prosperity is a plausible folk idea and how it should be described.
Funerals បុណ្យសព	The family keeps the body at home for some days, with monks chanting, offerings and a vigil. Mourners wear white. The body is cremated. Ceremonies follow after seven days and after one hundred days.	Episode 1's vigil, the white tent, the seventh night. Confirm vigil customs, white mourning dress, and the meaning of the seventh day.
Pchum Ben ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ	A fifteen-day festival in the lunar month that usually falls in September or October. Families bring food to pagodas for the monks and rice balls for ancestors and wandering spirits, believed to be released at this time.	Episode 2's night and the Pret. Confirm offering practices and whether lay people would be at the pagoda at night.
Pret ប្រេត	In Buddhist belief, hungry ghosts suffering for past greed; often described with huge bellies and tiny mouths or thin necks, unable to eat.	Blind hunters in Episode 2. Their blindness is our invention; confirm their appearance and that they can be shown as sympathetic.
Betel	Areca nut, betel leaf and lime, traditionally offered to guests and used in rituals and offerings to ancestors and spirits.	Episode 1's offering tray. Confirm the correct contents and arrangement.
Pagoda etiquette	Shoes off in sacred buildings; respect for monks (women do not touch monks); Buddha images treated with great respect; specific behaviour around stupas holding ashes.	Episode 2. The player must never be able to act disrespectfully towards monks or Buddha images.
Forest spirits ខ្មោចព្រៃ	Folk belief in dangerous spirits in forests at night, and in the taboo against answering a voice that calls your name.	Episode 4. Confirm the taboo's wording and region.
Drowned spirits	Folk belief in the spirits of those who die violently or in water, sometimes linked to women who die in childbirth.	Episode 3 (Kanha). Highly sensitive; confirm terms and how to show her with dignity.

Topic	General understanding	How the game uses it · to confirm
Colonial history	Cambodia was a French protectorate from 1863. Rubber plantations expanded in the eastern provinces in the 1920s, with many labourers recruited from northern and central Vietnam under harsh conditions.	Episode 4. Confirm with a historian; show labourers with dignity.
Mrenh Kongveal ព្រេញគង្វាល	Small, child-like guardian spirits in Khmer folk belief, often described as protecting homes, fields or people.	Kanha's baby, Pich, as a gentle helper (Ep 3, 5). Confirm that linking a stillborn child to a Mrenh Kongveal is appropriate, and how such spirits are spoken of.
Dance របាំ	Khmer classical dance is treasured heritage, historically performed as an offering; village folk dances belong to festivals and harvests.	Only as moments of beauty: a harvest dance in the Ep 2 flashback, Apsara carvings dancing in the Ep 5 Water trial. Check gestures and context with a dancer or the advisor.
Phnom Kulen ភ្នំគូលេន	A sacred mountain north of Angkor with ancient carvings, waterfalls and pilgrimage sites; still an active place of worship.	Episode 5. Keep the in-game sanctuary fictional; avoid copying specific real shrines.

04 Language Guidelines

Khmer text	Written by native speakers, never machine-translated. Use Unicode Khmer and test rendering in the game engine (stacked consonants, vowel signs).
Fonts	Preah Vihear for interface and documents; a decorative display face for the logo, chosen with the advisor.
Romanisation	Use common English spellings for places (Battambang, Kampong Cham, Tonle Sap). For other terms, choose one spelling, list it in the glossary and use it everywhere.
Names	Khmer names place the family name first. Characters are mostly addressed by given name with a kinship term.
Kinship terms	*Yay* (grandmother), *Ta* (grandfather), *Pu* (uncle), *Bong* (older sibling or cousin), *Oun* (younger). Confirm exact usage between Sora and Vuthy.
Numerals	Khmer numerals ០ ១ ២ ៣ ៤ ៥ ៦ ៧ ៨ ៩ appear in Episode 3's safe puzzle; the sketchbook shows a key.

05 Master Glossary

All terms used across the documents. Status: Draft = our best understanding · Query = known doubt. Once the advisor confirms a term, mark it Confirmed.

Term	Khmer	Meaning	Ep	Status
Boon Sop	បុណ្យសព	Funeral ceremony (series title)	All	Draft
The Unbroken Debt	បំណុលមិនដាច់	Series subtitle	All	Draft
Neak Ta	អ្នកតា	Guardian spirit of the land	All	Draft
Sora · Yay Mey · Sok · Vuthy	សូរ៉ា · យាយមុី · សុខ · វុទ្ធី	Character names	All	Query
Chea · Chhun · Kanha	ជា · ឈុន · កញ្ញា	Ancestor names	All	Query
Funeral tent	ឆាងបុណ្យ	Ceremonial pavilion	1	Query
Phteah Rong Doeung	ផ្ទះឆាងដើង	Traditional gabled house	1	Draft
Krom Phteah	ក្រោមផ្ទះ	Space under a stilt house	1	Draft
Kanteal	កន្ទេល	Woven mat	1	Draft
Sleok Rith	ស្លឹករឹត	Palm-leaf manuscript	1, 2	Draft
Chong Kben	សំពត់ចងក្បិន	Wrapped trousers	1	Draft
Sbai	ស្បៃ	Shoulder sash	1	Draft
Coffin	មឈូស	Coffin	1	Draft
Clay jar	ពាង	Large water jar	1	Draft
Oil lamp	ចង្កៀង	Lamp	1	Draft
Betel / areca	ម្ជូ / ស្លា	Betel leaf / areca nut	1	Query
Protective thread	—	White cotton thread	1, 2, 5	Query
Pchum Ben	ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ	Festival of the Dead	2	Draft
Bay Ben	បាយបិណ្ឌ	Rice-ball offerings	2	Draft
Pret	ប្រេត	Hungry ghost	2, 5	Draft
Wat	វត្ត	Pagoda	2	Draft
Chedi	ចេតិយ	Stupa holding ashes	2	Draft
Vihear	វិហារ	Prayer hall	2	Draft
Kuti	កុដិ	Monk's living quarters	2	Draft
Hawtrai	ហៅត្រៃ	Scripture library	2	Draft
Naga	នាគ	Serpent guardian	2, 5	Draft

Term	Khmer	Meaning	Ep	Status
Betel box	ប្រអប់ស្លា	Box for betel and areca	2	Query
Venerable (title)	ព្រះតេជគុណ	Form of address for a senior monk	2	Query
Tonle Sap	ទន្លេសាប	The great lake	3	Draft
Sampan	សំប៉ាន	Small wooden boat	3	Draft
Chhlong Tonle	—	Drowned water spirit	3	Query
Pa Lok	—	The fisherman's name	3	Query
Chamkar Kaosou	ចំការកៅស៊ូ	Rubber plantation	4	Draft
Phteah Barang	ផ្ទះបារាំង	French colonial house	4	Draft
Khmaoch Prey	ខ្មោចព្រៃ	Forest ghost	4	Draft
Tapping knife	—	Rubber-tapping knife	4	Query
Phnom Kulen	ភ្នំគូលេន	Sacred mountain	5	Draft
Sima	សីមា	Boundary stone	5	Draft
Banyan	ជ្រៃ	Banyan tree	5	Draft
Apsara	អប្សរា	Celestial dancer	5	Draft
Linga / Yoni	លិង្គ / យោនី	Shaivite sacred stones	5	Draft
Smot	ស្មូត	Buddhist funeral chanting	1, 5	Draft
Mrenh Kongveal	ម្រេញគង្វាល	Child-like guardian spirit	3, 5	Query
Pich	ពេជ្រ	Name of Kanha's baby ("diamond")	3, 5	Query
Robam	របាំ	Dance	2, 5	Draft
Pinpeat / Roneat	ពិណពាទ្យ / រនាត	Classical ensemble / xylophone	All	Draft

06 Sensitive Content Register

#	Content	Ep	Concern	Status
1	A Neak Ta as the antagonist	All	Neak Ta are respected protectors	Open
2	Funeral vigil, coffin, corpse moving	1	Real grief practices used for horror	Open
3	Betel offering and the blessing line	1	Accuracy of ritual	Open
4	Funeral chanting during the ritual	1, 5	Use of real religious chant	Open
5	Pchum Ben and the Pret as enemies	2	A living festival; suffering spirits	Open
6	Monk character and pagoda setting	2	Depiction of monks and sacred spaces	Open
7	Mother who died in childbirth as a spirit	3	Grief, death in childbirth	Open
8	Plantation labour and colonial history	4	Real suffering; Vietnamese and Khmer workers	Open
9	Linga and yoni altar; blood offering	5	Sacred objects still venerated; blood	Open
10	Riverbed carvings evoking real Kulen sites	5	Real pilgrimage sites	Open
11	Kanha's stillborn baby as a guardian spirit (Pich)	3, 5	Infant death; folk belief	Open
12	Harvest dance and dancing Apsara carvings	2, 5	Heritage art used in a horror game	Open

07 Review Log

Copy this table for each review. Keep the log in the repository so decisions are never lost.

Date	Advisor	Question / item	Answer / advice	Decision and documents changed